

Images of the Desert — Shepherd

PRIMARY TEXT: PSALM 23

We all may envision this picture of desert differently, based on where we live or which literal deserts we have journeyed through in our lives.

Hot, barren, dry, endless, vast...

Cactus, sand, pyramids, palm trees, mirages, camels...

Warm sunsets, endless sea of stars in the nighttime sky...

**...the wilderness
becomes a lesson
in listening**

Through the Text, we see it as an original place of meeting with God, where God makes Himself known and knows His people intimately, and a place of growth (uncomfortably so). As we learn in this episode, the wilderness also becomes a lesson in listening.

The desert, in all its vast unknowns and terrifying beauty, is a place where Israel learned to hear and recognize God's voice just as sheep do their shepherd. They became so familiar to the tones and pitch of the shepherd's voice that they followed it above all others.

Midbar. A place of speaking. Where God continually provides for His people. Teaching them to follow Him, to listen for His voice, and trust He would provide just what they needed—just enough, just in time. Just like the image of a shepherd.

What a humbling, and challenging, thing to grasp. It is not one marked with prosperity and treasures overflowing. It is a lesson of God's providence in the most difficult, stretching, and tiring of moments to provide just what is needed at the moment it should come.

**Our paths of
righteousness
become rocky terrain.**

This adds new depth to Psalm 23, our visuals of green pastures turn to tufts of, kind of, grass. Our paths of righteousness become rocky terrain in often sweltering heat. The still waters we lie by are not as "picturesque" as our Sunday School felt boards had us believe.

The desert is beautiful, yet unknown and vastly different from the empires and Egypts we leave behind. Many people in the Text entered the desert. When they left, they were not the same. This can be said for us when we enter our desert moments—where we just need a little bit of rest. We just need a break. We just need the smallest bit of shade to lay our head under in order to keep moving forward tomorrow.

In the desert we may feel isolated or worn down. Fatigued and near giving up completely; however, as we follow His voice, just around the corner—that shade, that rest, that community, that place of hope, that manna from Heaven appears.

There are so many voices yelling or whispering at us throughout our lives, attempting to overwhelm the voice we long to hear. In the middle of my basketball games years ago, standing at the free throw line, I could drown out all voices but one. “Come on, Sissy!” my dad would yell. That voice was known, familiar, always just enough—enough annoyance at the nickname, enough drive to keep me going, enough love and empathy and understanding in that exhausting moment to get me to the next whistle.

Which voice do we seek to hear and know?

What still amazes me from my own Israel desert experience was the real shepherd of the desert—young women, teenagers. Their voices were the ones heard through the desert, leading their sheep with their songs, staff in hand. Painting an image for us of how different our Shepherd’s voice truly is in comparison to the voices the world tells us we should be listening to.

Which voice do we seek to hear and know? To trust? Which voice has spent so much time near us that we recognize it above all the others? This isn’t the first time we’ve discussed listening to God’s voice above all others. Way back in Episode 2, we raised the question *Whose voice are you listening to?* So we are reminded of this question again here. Are you listening to the voice that says you are very good—the voice of the good Shepherd? The voice that seeks to bring you closer to Him, closer to the Kingdom, and closer to the garden—the voice so different from the empire’s that we can’t help but recognize it for whose it is.

PRAYER

God, our Good Shepherd,

*You guide us through the desert with Your voice
singing over the heat in the face of the sun.*

Leaning on Your staff, You guide us, protect us.

*Sometimes we question and doubt
yet You bring us back into Your fold,
and never stop calling our name.*

*You lead us to just enough—
enough water, enough food, enough shade—just in time.*

*May we know Your voice,
following You so closely on those paths of righteousness,
that Yours is the only song
that urges us to move, to act.*

*In the desert, may we learn even more to Trust the Story,
and wait on every word from You,
our Shepherd.*

Amen

THE FOUR PILLARS

EPISODE 26

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

What might be important to meditate over from the Exodus journey, laws of Leviticus, or images from Psalm 23? What part of these Texts challenge you to dig deeper?



COMMUNITY

How does your community hear the Shepherd's voice? How might you share and be this image in your community, to trust in God's timing and faithfulness in just enough?



DISCIPLESHIP

Who can you bring alongside you to model and experience being led by the Shepherd—to listen together for God's voice, and to trust that God will lead through the images of Psalm 23—even if those images look a bit different than we initially believed?



WRESTLING

What are you wrestling with? The new contextual images of Psalm 23? The meaning of the desert as a place of speaking? What questions do you have to dig deeper into? Remember, questions and wrestling are good! Especially in community.



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE SPIRITUAL FORMATION

We believe that **if we do our part in creating space for God, He will fill it.** What spiritual practices or disciplines might you need to connect with God and learn to recognize His voice? How might the smallest practice fill you with more of Him? What practice could you refine, pick up again, or challenge yourself to try for the very first time? If you haven't yet, start by creating that space—He will fill it. Sometimes these spiritual practices may feel like a wilderness—and that may be just the right thing—or just enough, just in time.

CONSIDERING CAMPUS YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

We believe young adults are shaping the future, and they need to experience God through people like you. **They need to see what it looks like to follow God as sheep follow a shepherd!** What it means to know God's voice, and to trust the promise of Psalm 23 in its context. Let God do the heavy lifting, follow Him as your Shepherd, and be on the lookout for those young people to help them hear God's voice for themselves.

SACRED STATION THEOLOGY OF WORK

Imagine how our world, our theology of work, might be different if we lived each moment in tune with the voice of the Shepherd. Living in intimacy with God is about how you put Him on display, in how you pursue and experience your 9–5, and how that changes you and the people you meet in the desert or in the promised land. Does your physical work put you in a position to be a walking image of God's love? A position to lead others to experience and hear the voice of God? Does your voice sound like Him? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products can make an impact. **You are doing a sacred work—no matter where you are.**